

Life *in* water

Water covers nearly three-quarters of our planet's surface, and the first life evolved in the oceans. So it's no surprise that so many living things make water their home. Animals with gills spend their entire lives submerged, but others that breathe air must occasionally come to the surface to survive.

Freshwater

Rivers

Freshwater falling as rain on land gathers in channels and ultimately flows downhill to the ocean. Life thrives at every stage, from tumbling streams and waterfalls to wide, slow rivers.



Manatees make their home in rivers.



Diving beetles can survive in small ponds.

Bogs and marshes

Some kinds of plants can take root in pools of water, while others float on the surface, creating dense vegetation. These bogs and marshes provide good cover for predators and prey alike.



Caimans hunt for fish and the occasional water bird on the marshy banks of the Amazon River in South America.

Ponds and lakes

Some animals can survive in ponds or tiny pools. These can dry up in times of drought. Other creatures live in deep lakes so big you cannot see the other side.

Coral reef

Tiny anemone-like animals called coral polyps grow in colonies that produce rocky skeletons called reefs. Coral reefs grow around warm coastlines and are home to more kinds of animals than any other ocean habitat.



Mangrove swamp

Few land plants can survive in salty ocean water, but mangrove trees are an exception. They grow rooted in mud along tropical shorelines, providing a forest habitat for animals that live between the land and the sea.

